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● Editorial Office: Living Media India Ltd. F-14/15, Connaught Place New Delhi 110001; Phones: 23315801-4;
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Phones: Toll-free number: 1800 1800 100 (from BSNL/MTNL lines); (95120) 2479900 from Delhi and
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General Manager (Sales), Living Media India Limited, 201 Competent House, F-14, Middle Circle, Connaught Place,

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Kamala City, Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Panel, Mumbai 400013; Phone: 24983355; Fax: 24982266 ● Hamilton

House, 1-A, Connaught Place, New Delhi 110001; Phone: 23322333; Fax: 23327330 ● 98-A, Dr. Radhakrishnan Salai,

2nd Floor, Mylapore, Chennai-600 004; Phones: 28478526-41; Telex: 041-6177 Into In; Fax: 28472178; Cable:

Livmedia Chennai ● 201-204 Richmond Towers, 2nd Floor, 12, Richmond Road, Bangalore-560025; Phones:

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● 2/C, "Suryarath Bldg", 2nd Floor, Behind White House, Panchsai, Office C.G. Road, Ahmedabad-380006;

Phone: 26560393, 26560929; Fax: 26565293

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A year ago, in tune with the general festive season and end of year feel-good factor, we decided to draw up a selection of the best that India had to offer. We meant to go off the tourist track and highlight the little known aspects of what could be enjoyed in India by way of a total mind, body and soul experience. Our 2006 list talked about everything—from the place where you could get the best view of the Himalayas as well as the street stall that served up the best omelette in the country to the best book store, the best night club, the most idyllic meal to the best long drive.

That cover story generated such fierce in-house debate and enthusiastic reader feedback that we knew we were on to a good thing. This year we decided to give the Best of India another go, asking our bureaus countrywide to suggest different candidates for some more exceptional Indian experiences. This list is as diverse as the one in 2006, drawing from our correspondents' experiences while travelling on assignments for the magazine and their range of outside interests.

In order to nail down a definitive 'best', our reporters were only too glad to go the extra mile. Chandigarh-based Associate Editor Ramesh Vinayak went paragliding in Billing in the Kangra valley, which is a global paragliding mecca because of the profusion of 'thermals' (warm air currents) that rise off the heated landscape and hill slopes around it. In Billing, such ideal gliding conditions last much longer than they do elsewhere in the world, attracting adventure junkies to this relatively unknown slice of Himachal Pradesh.

Special Correspondent M.G. Radhakrishnan, our man in Thiruvananthapuram, checked out an ayurveda resort in Kalari Kovilakam, Kerala, which has been described as a haven of "four-star asceticism". After two weeks of no-frills living, which has them restricted to a compound, prescribed diets, courses of yoga, meditation and treatments, guests from around the world revel in the austerity which they say leaves them feeling younger, rejuvenated and energised.

From Bangalore, Special Correspondent Nirmala Ravindran confirmed that an annual gathering of performing artistes and academicians in Shimoga, in central Karnataka, featured such an unprecedented interaction between eminent artistes and an audience drawn from the local community, that it had to qualify as the must-do pilgrimage for all committed culture vultures. There are many others that qualify as the finest experiences for the mind, body and soul that can be found in India.

This is an entirely subjective list, from the exotic to the everyday, from the exorbitant to the affordable. Our overall intention was to highlight the special treasures to be found in India, whether on the busiest junctions of our cities or hidden in remote corners.

Like the tourism promotion line says, India is truly incredible. There is no end to new discoveries. We hope you enjoy reading them as much as we did reporting them.

(Aroon Purie)



Our Oct 2006 cover